



Defining Your Goals

One of the first steps in starting a business is to define what you want to do and why you want to do it. This will help you focus your ideas more clearly and allow you to start making specific plans.

Defining your purpose

When starting a business, first decide what you want to achieve. Known as your business “vision,” this is a long-term view of what your business will become. To then help make that vision become a reality, identify why you want to start *this* business and not *another*. For example, you may want to open a travel agency, but why? It may be

because you want to offer exciting trips, to serve a particular market, or because you simply see it as a way to make money. This is the “purpose” behind your business vision. Use this to inform your decisions and to focus your plans. For instance, an agency offering unique vacations would be planned differently from one aimed at only making money. Your vision and

purpose embody your business, which you can use when deciding your strategies and planning your working procedures and practices. Share them with other people involved in your business from the start, including investors, customers, clients, and staff by encapsulating them in a “mission statement” (see right) that sums up you and your business.

Setting out your values

While deciding the vision and purpose of your business, also consider the values you want to uphold, such as honesty, integrity, value for money, and passion. These provide a map and compass to guide your decision-making and should be reflected in how the business operates. Incorporate these values throughout the business, and communicate them with others so that everyone dealing with you knows what you stand for. For example, a travel agency catering to older travelers may choose “commitment, quality, adventure, and luxury” as its business values.



**“People don’t buy what you do;
they buy why you did it.”**

Simon Sinek, author and motivational speaker, 2009